

Wilson's Hot Bat Threat to Millers

By BOB BEEBE
Minneapolis Star Staff Writer

If Minneapolis and Denver follow precedent, their American Association final playoff series opening at Metropolitan stadium tonight won't last long.

Twice before, since Denver entered the league in 1955, the Millers and Bears have met in the playoff, but in the two series they have played only eight games.

In 1955, en route to their

minor league grand slam, the Millers belted the Bears in four straight in the first round. Then last year Den-



G. Wilson Schroll

ver chocked off Minneapolis with only four runs to sweep four first-round games. They continued through the finals to a Little World Series triumph.

Neither team appears equipped to perform the feat again, but there is one fellow still around who has been on the winning side in all eight games—George Wilson.

The Thumper was one of the big Miller guns in the 1955 sweep. Last year he was on the Denver side. Now, significantly, he is on one of his batting rampages with the Bears again.

"He's been our most consistent clutch hitter for weeks," says Manager Andy Cohen.

In the Charleston series which found the Bears closing out the champion Senators 4-3 with a 9-6 victory Wednesday night, Wilson got 12 hits in 29 times at bat for a .414 average. In the last three games he has driven in eight runs with seven for 13.

Catcher Johnny Blanchard also is hitting with his usual late-season fervor. He drove in 10 runs in the series and carried the attack in Charleston before Wilson picked it up in Denver.

Al Schroll, with five days to get ready since he shut out Wichita last Friday, will be the Minneapolis starter in tonight's 8:15 game.

He has a 1-3 record against Denver this season.

COHEN REPORTED all his athletes healthy on arrival this morning but admits a pitching problem. "I've had to make pretty free use of the staff lately and no one is rested," he pointed out. "So tonight I'll start either Leigh Lawrence, a right-hander, or Ed Donnelly, a left-hander, and give Johnny Gabler another day of rest. I had to use him an inning to save the game for Mark Freeman last night."

Minneapolis bases its hopes for victory on pitching and improved hitting, having averaged .270 against Wichita's top-rate hurling.

Last night in Denver the Bears piled up a 9-3 lead mostly against Art Houtteman and Jerry Davie in the first five innings. Then in the ninth Cohen had to use three pitchers to spike a final Senator rally.

Tickets went on sale today at Metropolitan stadium. Billy and Marty's and Duffy's for the three games scheduled here. Season ticket holders' game No. 4 tickets will be honored tonight.



CHARLES JOHNSON'S Lowdown on Sports

★ MINNEAPOLIS VS. DENVER for the American Association playoff championship!

What a natural! Here are two teams that have been the keenest of rivals ever since Denver came into the league. In each city these teams have been the biggest box office magnet.

Here they are, also rans in the regular pennant race, tangling for the right to get into the Junior World Series with the International league champions.

The series starts at Metropolitan stadium tonight. It is a strange turn of baseball that Denver has been hard to lick in Minneapolis with the Millers just as rugged when they have invaded the mile-high city.

Once again, a pennant winner couldn't get through its first playoff round. It's one of those quirks that happens so often. Many expect it annually.

There is no joy in Mudville (Charleston) these days. Denver dealt the champs a potion that will be hard to swallow in the West Virginia metropolis.

Flanagan-Akins Mystery

★ DEL FLANAGAN, THE ENIGMA of the ring, has another one of those "last-chance" bouts on his hands tonight in the St. Paul auditorium against Virgil Akins, accepted world's welterweight champion.

Heard that one before?

No professional battler this area has ever known has been knocked out of the local picture, revived and returned to big-money shots as often as the St. Paul 150-pounder.

Tonight's main event has every one guessing, but there seems to be enough interest among the railbirds to assure another big crowd. With ticket prices ranging from \$2 to \$11, promoter John Raleigh is talking about a \$35,000 house.

If that's what the final figures show, it is nothing short of incredible.

Boxing interest and patronage is at an all-time low almost everywhere, but the fans are coming out of hiding for this one.

It's a strange promotion.

FLANAGAN AND AKINS were under the same management—Bernie Glickman—until this bout was proposed.

There was some hurried shuffling. Flanagan's contract was sold to Bud Henning, St. Paul business man. He in turn guaranteed the champion \$10,000 to fight Del.

Whether this change in managers is only a temporary arrangement is something that has curious boxing fans asking questions.

Many others are wondering why Akins, on the verge of a valuable match with Carmen Basilio, would risk his